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In Search of National Traditions: Mapping Sri Lanka's Art Histories

Sujatha Arundathi Meegama



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Gal Vihara - Polonnaruwa

LAWTON

Sri Lanka's historical formation has been profoundly affected by three significant geographical factors—its island character, its location at the southern extremity of the South Asian subcontinent and its position at the centre of the Indian Ocean.

—Senake Bandaranayake¹

As an island Sri Lanka is a geographical entity in the Indian Ocean which, by virtue of its isolation from the Indian mainland, connotes a self-contained culture and evokes the idea of pure traditions. Indeed, islands are sometimes seen “as precursors of the modern, territorial nation state”,² with their physical boundedness and separation capturing finite national traditions. But the accumulation of *this* island's various names—Ceylon, Ilangai, Lanka, Lakdiva, Seilan, Serendib, Simhaladvipa, Tambapanni, Taprobane and many more³—suggest otherwise: the island has clearly meant different things to different people, and external contacts have been inevitable and central to its history and conceptualization. Thus the geography of an island may connect it to worlds beyond its shores, disrupting the perceived finite or homogeneous nature of its traditions; islands have “*roots* at home, while also deploying *routes* away from home.... The Island *is* a World; yet an Island *engages* the World.”⁴

The art-historical narratives in this volume explore this duality—the local roots and the regional and global routes—in the making of Sri Lanka's artistic heritages. These new essays, ranging from ancient to contemporary art, can be seen within a wider historiographical context, if one maps out the parallel emergence of notions of national traditions and connected art histories in the seminal art-historical accounts of this island by Ananda Coomaraswamy, Senerat Paranavitana and Senake Bandaranayake. Each has argued for an art history of Sri Lanka that engages with local and regional visual traditions, but with different terminologies and emphases, and reflecting a search for a national tradition that is at the same time connected to art worlds beyond the island. Drawing on these frameworks, I too argue for a simultaneous local and global engagement, but one that foregrounds the *connectedness* of the art histories of the island: the agents, the networks, the practices, the processes and the spaces of contact. The essays here emphasize the nuanced dialogues between local, regional and global visual traditions as a first step towards rethinking Sri Lanka's art histories as a complex, multifaceted, spatial and temporal field of interactions which cannot be reduced either to a selective

1

Joseph Lawton's photograph of Gal Vihara at Polonnaruwa taken between 1866 and 1872. Courtesy Lawton Albums, Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.



2

A 19th-century postcard of Anuradhapura. Private collection.

and exclusive canon in the service of particular ideologies of nationalism, or to a derivative product of external “influences”.

The standard narrative on Sri Lankan art, focused on Buddhist sculpture, architecture and painting and their “Sinhaleseness”,⁵ owes in part to the colonial project:⁶ in the 1820s and 1830s British officials and military men began recycling existing traditions about the island,⁷ creating a new historical framework.⁸ The British colonists’ discovery, translation, publication and inclusion of the Pali chronicles in new histories of the island helped create particular historical images. Thus the island’s history began with the history of the Sinhala people, while the Malabars (i.e. the Tamil people) were considered invaders and latecomers.⁹ The gigantic Buddhas and stupas rediscovered in the 1800s in the ancient cities of Anuradhapura and Polonnaruwa¹⁰ were understood as material evidence confirming some events of the chronicles.¹¹ Nineteenth-century photographs and postcards created for colonial documentation projects (figure 1) and for tourists (figure 2) highlighted the newly discovered monuments as remains of

the Buddhist religion.¹² And contemporary guidebooks to the island, especially to the ancient cities, resonated with these views.¹³ Colonialist historiography thus highlighted a particular Sinhala and Buddhist vision of the island’s artistic traditions, and also emphasized the glorious accomplishments of the past, which justified the colonial presence. Subsequent scholars, inheriting these frameworks, built on or questioned them while formulating their own ideas about national traditions and connected art histories, each affected by the concerns of their various socio-historical contexts.

In the early 1900s, Ananda Kentish Coomaraswamy (1877–1947), a geologist by training, began to write about Sri Lankan art. Coomaraswamy, who is considered to be the “first modern Sri Lankan art historian”,¹⁴ famously introduced South and Southeast Asian art to the West, and brought these traditions into the art-historical canon through his writings and his art collecting.¹⁵ His preliminary writings about Sri Lanka¹⁶ culminate in his 1908 magnum opus *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art*, which addresses different genres, mediums

3

Wall-painting depicting a scene from *Vessantara Jataka* in the Degaldoruva Rajamaha Vihara, Kandy, late 18th century. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.

and the ornamentation of diverse objects—architecture, woodwork, stonework, sculpture, painting, ivory, metalwork, lac-work, weaving, embroidery—as well as their makers.

Unlike most 19th-century archaeological reports or guidebooks on Sri Lanka, Coomaraswamy's book shifts attention from the ancient cities of Anuradhapura and Polonnaruwa to the arts of the living city of Kandy, which he and his wife, Ethel, encountered during their collaborative work in Sri Lanka (1902–06).¹⁷ In view of contemporary and subsequent scholars' emphasis on the ancient cities, Coomaraswamy's engagement with the arts of later periods is striking to say the least.¹⁸ For him Sri Lanka's art also meant the various contemporary material cultures of the island and not simply architecture, sculpture and painting.

In his book, while highlighting local visual traditions and their makers, Coomaraswamy famously states that "Sinhalese art is essentially Indian".¹⁹ This often-quoted passage indicates the extent to which he saw Sri Lanka as inseparable from its giant neighbour:

There is scarcely any part of Sinhalese life, or religion, or art, which is quite comprehensible without reference to India; the Sinhalese themselves are Indians; the greatness of their civilization dates from the wave of Indian influences that reach[ed] Ceylon through Asoka's missionaries; the air and soil in which the nation has grown and borne good fruit are Indian....²⁰

Coomaraswamy continues in this vein: as there is nothing on Sri Lankan soil that has not been



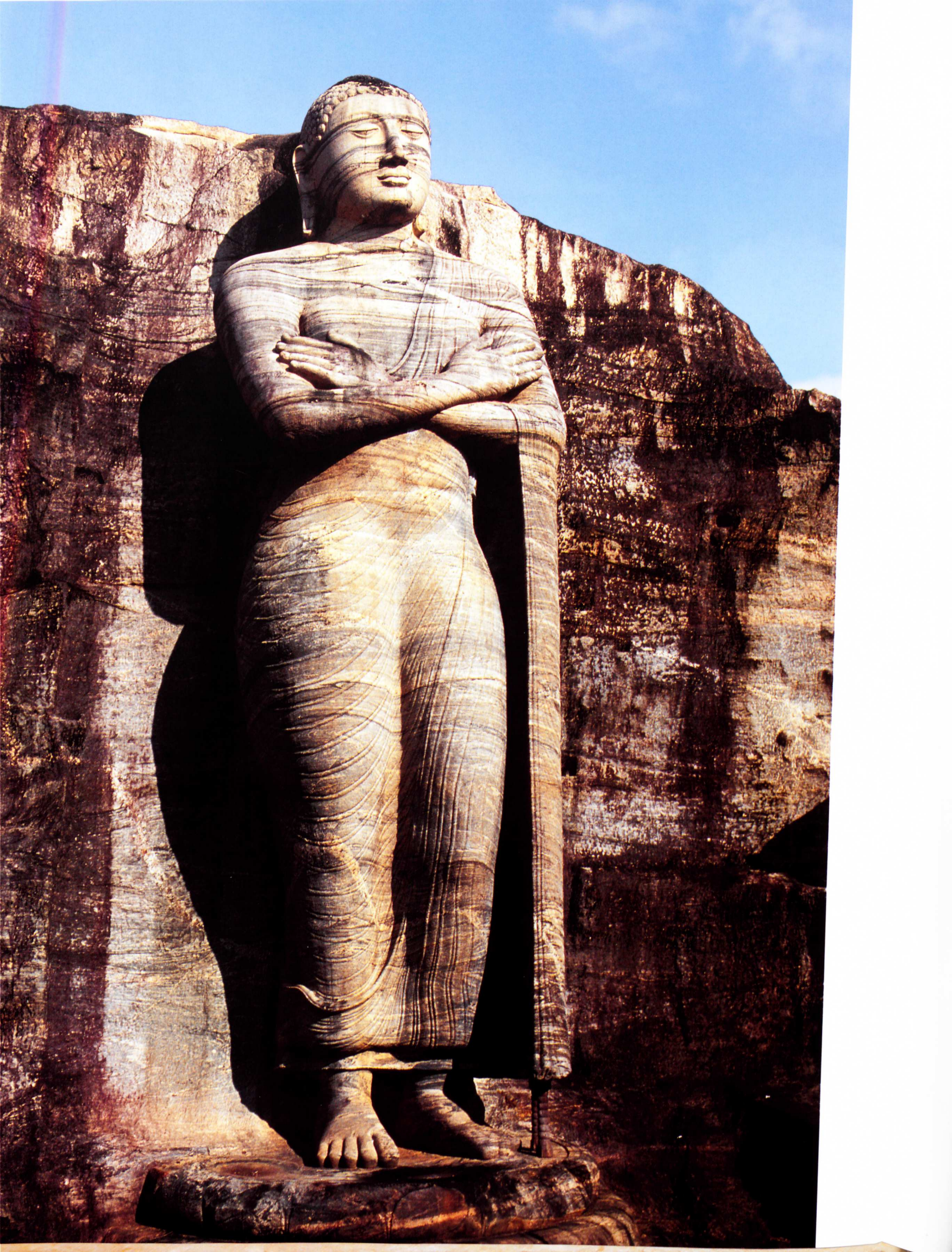


4
Vatadage at Polonnaruwa, 12th century. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.

5
Jetavana at Anuradhapura, 2nd century BCE–1st century CE. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.

6
Lankatilaka Pilimage at Polonnaruwa, 12th century. Photograph: Dinodia/Thierry Grun/collection-age fotostock.





touched by India (much like his understanding of Southeast Asian art),²¹ he locates Sri Lankan art as Indian. Thus, discussing Kandyan wall-paintings (figure 3), he suggests a similarity in style and subject matter to the relief carvings of Bharhut, and concludes that the latter are superior because they are closer in time to “the beginnings of a great tradition”.²² Here Sri Lankan art is not in any way seen as distinct or having its own local, historical or visual traditions.²³

This conclusion is in line with broader currents of thought emerging from the contemporaneous fervour of Indian nationalism and pan-Asian idealism. Indeed, T.K. Sabapathy, the eminent Singaporean art historian, places Coomaraswamy’s legacy in Southeast Asian art in the context of the birth of a “new vision of India”, seen as the “legitimizing center”, an idea deeply tied to “anti-colonialism and nationalism, and to a rediscovery of and new-found pride in Indian culture”.²⁴ Linking Sri Lanka to India was therefore natural, and Coomaraswamy was not a lone advocate of pan-Asian idealism. Okakura Kakuzo and Rabindranath Tagore were also great proponents of the unity of Asian art who “agreed that Asia had been united in the past by centuries of interaction and exchange”, especially with India.²⁵ India had become the new centre and it was imperative to be connected to it and all that it offered.

And yet this colonial context simultaneously gave birth to the notion of a national art. Coomaraswamy’s writings oscillate between Indian and Sinhalese, between his belief in the unity of Asian art and his belief in the distinctness of the island’s art produced by a Sinhala tradition. In his now famous “An Open Letter to the Kandyan Chiefs” (1905), he appealed to the Kandyan aristocracy to preserve, in their region, the many diverse, neglected monuments which he described as “national art”.²⁶ That year he also founded the Ceylon Social Reform Society, which advocated

a revival, not only of local arts and crafts, but also a reawakening of pride in local languages, literature, music and dress.²⁷ Thus local, and not only Indian nationalist, awakenings had some reverberations in the writing of Sri Lanka’s art histories, as distinct from those of India—an aspect that has yet to be fully explored.²⁸

Similar ideas but with different emphases were developed in the postcolonial period by Senerat Paranavitana (1896–1972), the first Sri Lankan archaeological commissioner (1940–56). An epigraphist and archaeologist by training, Paranavitana, too, started writing about the island early in his career.²⁹ By 1933, he had begun to write about Sri Lankan art, and



7
Standing Buddha at the
Gal Vihara, Polonnaruwa,
12th century. Photograph:
Dinodia/Christophe Boisvieux/
collection-age fotostock.

8
Guardstone at Anuradhapura,
8th–10th century. Courtesy
Department of Archaeology,
Sri Lanka.

in 1936 received his PhD from the University of Leiden, on the subject of stupas in Sri Lanka. However, as his main interests were in the historical periods before the arrival of the Portuguese, he continued the colonial emphasis on ancient cities. Scholars have discounted some of his later writings as overly speculative,³⁰ but like Coomaraswamy's work, his numerous publications reflect the search for a national tradition and are an indispensable reference on premodern Sri Lankan art.

Of these, two reflect a change in perspective over 50 years of research.³¹ Soon after independence in 1948, he wrote "Sinhalese Art and Culture" (1950; republished 1952),³² in which his focus was Sri Lanka's distinct contribution to Indian or Asian art, or the "art of the Sinhalese",³³ as he termed it. As examples, he discusses the island's circular shrines (figure 4), brick-built vaulted-roof shrines (figure 6), giant stupas (figure 5), guardstones (figure 8), moonstones, colossal Buddha images (figure 7), Sigiriya paintings (figure 9), and bronze figures. He highlights one bronze, a Shiva Nataraja from Polonnaruwa (figure 10), but notes that it belongs to the "art of the Tamil country";³⁴ in other words, according to Paranavitana, it is not part of the island's heritage but belongs to the traditions of South India. By the 13th century he sees "signs of exhaustion",³⁵ and he

ends by noting that the arts of later periods are addressed in Coomaraswamy's *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art*. From Paranavitana's examples, the sites of Anuradhapura and Polonnaruwa stand out as representing the pinnacle of Sri Lankan art, understood as Sinhalese and Buddhist—this emphasis suggests continuity with certain ideas from the colonial period, but also resonates with the nationalistic fervour of a newly independent country.³⁶ It also perhaps reflects Paranavitana's life-long work as an epigraphist and an archaeologist.

Twenty years later, Paranavitana's general conception of Sri Lankan art as distinctly Sinhalese and Buddhist had hardly changed, but in his *Art of the Ancient Sinhalese*,³⁷ which appeared the year before his death, he began his narrative by noting the geographical position of the island—its proximity to India—and suggesting that "the ancient culture and the art of the Island...should be derived from those of the great subcontinent".³⁸ The seeds of this line of thinking had appeared in his earlier publications,³⁹ but in this, Paranavitana's last grand narrative about Sri Lankan art, there is more of an emphasis on the island's connection to India. Indian culture has been, as he puts it, "preserved in Ceylon" since 2,000 years ago when Buddhism was introduced to the island; and like Coomaraswamy he frames Sri Lankan art within the sphere of Indian influence.⁴⁰ Deep connections to India recur in this piece, in characterizations of the foundations of the island's art, and in continual comparisons as the island's art evolves⁴¹—a framework reminiscent of Coomaraswamy's formulations, oscillating between the distinctness of Sinhalese art and its foundations in Indian art.

In response to Coomaraswamy's and Paranavitana's notions of India as the source for all things Sri Lankan,⁴² Senake Bandaranayake (1938–2015) proposed an alternative model for understanding Sri Lanka's artistic heritages. An



9
Wall-painting at Sigiriya, 5th century. Courtesy Department of Archaeology, Sri Lanka.

10
Bronze Shiva Nataraja from Polonnaruwa, 11th century. Courtesy Central Cultural Fund, Sri Lanka.



archaeologist, art historian, educator, university administrator and institution-builder, Bandaranayake made diverse contributions to Sri Lanka's art histories. Covering a wide range of topics from Sigiriya to Galle, his research cut across the island spatially and temporally: his bachelor's thesis was on Polonnaruwa, his doctoral dissertation on Anuradhapura (published as *Sinhalese Monastic Architecture* in 1974); his monograph *Rock and Wall Paintings of Sri Lanka* is the authoritative book on Sri Lankan painting; and in addition to the

premodern, he wrote about modernism, and encouraged contemporary Sri Lankan art.⁴³

Bandaranayake's critique of what he variously termed "Indianization", "diffusionism", the "external factor", the "Indo-centric model" or "influence", is pertinent to mapping out the historiography of Sri Lankan art, because besides the emphasis on ruins or ancient cities, he points to another framework that is found in colonialist historiography. Discussing the theory of Indianization, he notes that this view "denied to any colonized society (including India) the responsibility for having created its own history",⁴⁴ and he attempts to overturn certain ideas deeply embedded in Sri Lanka's colonial historiography by rethinking the island's relationships with outside art worlds.

Thus, while acknowledging the significance of the "relationship between the external and internal factors in the island's Indian Ocean location and its global context", Bandaranayake has always argued for a "specificity of a Sri Lankan tradition in the wider context of Monsoon Asia".⁴⁵ In the context of climate, architecture, religion and other features, "the island [has] an intermediate positioning between South and Southeast Asia"⁴⁶—another important relationship that is often overlooked because of our obsession with India. These ideas are developed in two seminal essays, "Sri Lanka and Monsoon Asia: Hypotheses on the Unity and Differentiation of Cultures" and "Approaches to the External Factor in Sri Lanka's Historical Formation".⁴⁷

Both essays address similar concerns. In "Sri Lanka and Monsoon Asia", Bandaranayake places Sri Lanka within the geo-cultural category of "Monsoon Asia" but asks us to reflect on what he calls "the law of the internal dynamic", defined as "the process that derives from the encounter of humans and their environment and with each other in the territory within which that culture evolves". His "internal

dynamic” comprises “three interconnected and often inseparable paths of development”—the last of which is “the acquisition and adaptation, according to its own needs and possibilities, of the forms and concepts that have been developed in similar or in more advanced or less advanced cultures among its neighbours”. He argues that it is this last aspect which is often framed as “influence”, a concept he derides because it displaces the agencies that are at work. In this process of appropriating, we forget “the *dynamism of the society that takes* rather than *the society from which the form or concept is taken*”.⁴⁸

As a case study, Bandaranayake looks at the architectural traditions of Sri Lanka, comparing various structures found on the island to those in the building traditions of Monsoon Asia. He discovers two distinct styles: wholly masonry

structures (figure 11) versus timber structures and timber-and-masonry structures (figure 12). He concludes that “the formal architecture of Sri Lanka from the period BC to modern times has consisted almost entirely of structures in timber or timber-and-masonry”, indicating that Sri Lanka’s visual traditions relate “as much or more to a wider Monsoon Asian pattern—with its geometrical centre in Southeast Asia—than to the dominantly masonry tradition of formal historical architecture in India”. This discovery allows him to question the long-held belief that “the country’s historical evolution was wholly linked with that of the Indian subcontinent”.⁴⁹ Thus Bandaranayake’s formulations indicate the need to rethink Coomaraswamy’s and Paranavitana’s ideas about Sri Lanka’s connections exclusively to India.

11

A wholly masonry structure (left) at Natha Devale, 14th century. Photograph: Dinodia/Stefan Auth/collection-image BROKER.



Bandaranayake continues his explorations of Sri Lanka's historical formation in "Approaches to the External Factor", which foregrounds the geography of the island. As against descriptive (cultural, economic and political) classifications, he proposes three analytical categories, based on geography, for an understanding of the island's relationship with the outside world: first, "the emergence of Sri Lanka itself as a geopolitical entity"; second, "its distinct character and structure as an island civilization [that] stands in contradistinction to its close relationship with the South Asian mainland"; and third, "Sri Lanka's position at the center of the Indian ocean". Bandaranayake argues that these three spheres of analysis are not fixed categories but closely interwoven strands that go into making up Sri Lanka's history.⁵⁰ So when he examines

the broad sweep of Sri Lanka's external relations, he notes that new scholarship "must take into account the operation of internal dynamics and external relations with other parts of the world, especially with the other regions and countries in the Indian Ocean theatre",⁵¹ and not only with the Indian subcontinent.

It is only for the period before the 16th century that Bandaranayake proposes this more balanced theoretical framework—one that takes into account the local, regional and global nature of the island's artistic heritages.⁵² However, his ideas also have resonance for our understanding of the art produced in the early modern, colonial and postcolonial worlds. The present volume attempts to actualize such a framework, through concrete case studies from different phases of Sri Lanka's historical contacts with outside art worlds.

12

Embekke Devale at Kandy, a timber-and-masonry structure built in the 18th century. Photograph: Dinodia/Stefan Auth/collection-image BROKER.



Despite their varied understandings of Sri Lankan art histories, Coomaraswamy, Paranavitana and Bandaranayake share a common frame of reference: the interaction between the national and the regional, the internal and the external, or, what could today be phrased as the local and the global.⁵³ All three acknowledge the existence of local and regional traditions, but to different degrees and using different terminologies. Coomaraswamy and Paranavitana first noted the presence of the local and the regional, but it is only Bandaranayake who articulates a much broader engagement with the regional and the global, and a possible *simultaneity* of these traditions through his understanding of Sri Lanka's geography—as an island at the tip of the Indian subcontinent, but in the middle of a maritime highway on the way to everywhere.

Taking these understandings of national traditions and connected art histories as a possible framework to be expanded upon, I have chosen to highlight *relationships* between the local, the regional and the global, or the subtle and complex “processes of connectedness”,⁵⁴ suggesting that all are equally important in understanding the art histories of Sri Lanka. However, as we listen to new scholarly voices, we realize that there is still an emphasis on the island's connections to India as well as Buddhist art, so this collection of essays does not claim to be complete or comprehensive in its scope. It is but a small step towards rethinking Sri Lanka's art histories.

As with any digestible art history of a specific geographical entity, I have opted for a loosely chronological narrative touching on objects or themes that represent distinct historical phases—from the ancient cities to a colonial port city. For the first time, art in Anuradhapura jostles for attention with the modern painter M. Sarlis in the same intellectual space. However, including non-Buddhist art

or post-16th-century art in an additive way would not be productive,⁵⁵ nor would simply going beyond the Sinhala Buddhist narrative or expanding the range of what are treated as canonical works. The essays in this volume illustrate that the non-canonical, too, convey narratives that are essential to understanding the complexities of the island's artistic heritages. They attend to the negotiations between visual, religious and cultural boundaries seen throughout the island's histories, and, alongside the objects, pay close attention to their producers and patrons. Through this attentiveness to the processes of connectedness, each essay in this volume inserts the island in wider circles, yet reminds us of local traditions that respond to broader networks. Some of the essays do this to a greater extent, taking us in slightly different directions which imply that at times the local takes precedence over the regional or the global; sometimes the regional and at other times the global overshadows the local—not all objects and narratives are located simultaneously in the local, the regional and the global. Thus, drawing on new voices, some writing on Sri Lanka for the first time, this volume brings to the table often-overlooked aspects of Sri Lanka's art histories.

Even in exploring the possibility of narrating new art histories, we begin again with Anuradhapura and Polonnaruwa, the two great historic cities which have dominated narratives on Sri Lankan art, and whose artistic monuments have usually been portrayed as Buddhist and Sinhala in nature. Catherine Becker and R. Mahalakshmi take us to these sites, each suggesting alternative ways to understand their complexities. Becker's “Wherefore Does the Earth Quake? Artistic Exchange and the Construction of Buddhist Homelands in Andhra and Sri Lanka” develops a new framework for looking at specific concerns—motifs and narrative strategies—shared between Anuradhapura and Andhra in advancing their notions of constructing Buddhist homelands.

Using a cross-media methodology that compares the narrative reliefs from Andhra with the stories in the *Mahavamsa*, Becker convincingly makes the case, based on her examination of a relief from the British Museum that once adorned a railing at Amaravati, that a story which she teases out about the creation of Buddhist homelands has a similar function both in the textual tradition of Anuradhapura and in the visual tradition of Andhra.

Mahalakshmi's essay "Beyond the Politics of Conquest: Brahmanical Iconography in Polonnaruva" explores the cultural landscape of Polonnaruva within a Braudelian framework and borrowing K. Indrapala's ideas on the South India-Sri Lanka factor, reminding us of the significance of geography in Sri Lanka's complex relationship with South India. Mahalakshmi examines the sculptures of the brahmanical temples in Polonnaruva, as they exist now and through a 19th-century photograph, to reconstruct the sculptural programme of one of these temples. Comparing the standard iconographic programme in South India, she concludes that the inclusion of sculptures of certain deities indicates a new programme at Polonnaruva. Thus the temples at Polonnaruva should be seen not as replicas of South Indian temples but as negotiated spaces in a new and local context.

Packiyathan Ahilan's "Political Boundaries or Cultural Zones? Recontextualizing the Iconography of Post-Polonnaruva Buddha Images" returns to the Buddhist art world. In a tentative exploration of the Buddha image in Sri Lanka, Ahilan suggests a closer engagement with the bronze Buddhas from Nagapattinam, arguing that the main concern in scholarship has been to formulate a classical Buddha image for the Anuradhapura period, while sculptures produced after the demise of the two glorious centres have been relegated as aesthetically weak. By examining the similarities between the post-Polonnaruva Buddha images produced in Gampola and Dambulla and those at Nagapattinam, Ahilan argues for possible connections between the Buddhist communities of this South Indian port city and Sri Lanka.

To understand Sri Lankan art and its complexities, we also need to go beyond the island's immediate neighbours and engage with the different European colonial encounters of the early-modern period, from the arrival of the Portuguese in 1506, to the Dutch (1638–1796) and to the British (1796–1948). My own essay shifts our lens to a group of small ivory boxes produced as luxury objects for the Renaissance *kunstkammers* of the Portuguese royal court. In "Albrecht Dürer in Sri Lanka: A 16th-Century Ivory-Carver's Encounter with a European

13a and b

Ketchimalai Mosque in Beruwala, and tomb within. Photographs: (13a) Sujatha Meegama; (13b) BT Options.





14

A keramat on Kusu Island
Singapore. Photograph:
Peh Yang Yu.

Print” I focus on the producers of these exquisite ivories: examining a Sri Lankan ivory casket that features two depictions of Albrecht Dürer’s *The Bagpipe Player* (1514), I argue that it accrued a new meaning when the print migrated to South Asia; and rather than framing this engagement with Dürer as a derivative copy, I locate the ivory-carver’s appropriation and visual response in the wider visual worlds of South Asia.

The world of 19th-century Buddhist temple paintings in the colonial city of Colombo and its surroundings is the focus of T. Sanathanan’s essay “Visualizing the Sinhala Buddhist Nation: The Temple Murals of Sarlis Master”. Sanathanan introduces us to the paintings of M. Sarlis, drawing an important connection between this new mural tradition and the parallel development of Sinhala theatre, both patronized by the Sinhala bourgeois. He convincingly shows how Sarlis brought Buddhist and national narratives and societal concerns together in one space to create new magical Buddhist art worlds.

The engagement with outside art worlds continues in the two final essays. Sonal Khullar’s narrative about the Sri Lankan modernist

painter George Keyt reminds us of *Marg*’s long-term engagement with Sri Lanka: *Marg* included two essays on Keyt in its first volume in 1947, and its first monograph, published in 1950 and authored by Martin Russell, was dedicated to the artist.⁵⁶ In her essay “Sea Change: George Keyt’s Murals at Gotami Vihara, 1939–40”, Khullar takes us to a small Buddhist temple in Colombo called Gotami Vihara, now famous for its modernist interpretations of the life of the Buddha, and analyses the ways in which George Keyt invokes a national past—and simultaneously departs from it—to engage with diverse visual traditions in South Asia and elsewhere. Khullar’s discussion foregrounds the ways in which Keyt cites Kandy, Sigiriya, Ajanta and Picasso to create a multilayered interpretation of the life of the Buddha that engages with local, regional and global visual traditions.

Finally, as this volume—unlike typical hardbound scholarly art histories or lavishly illustrated coffee-table books—places the world of Sri Lankan contemporary art alongside the country’s ancient archaeological heritage, it compels us to acknowledge the contemporary

as integral to Sri Lanka's art histories, and not as something practised on the fringes.⁵⁷ Sharmini Pereira's "*This Island: The Idea of Landscape in Contemporary Sri Lankan Art*" shifts our perspective directly onto the physicality of the island that has been a site of much contention. Pereira explores locality, scenery, political territory and new social orders in the landscape of the island, all invoked through multiple mediums. Through the collective but diverse responses of modernist and contemporary artists, she juxtaposes early, idyllic views of the island with later violence in the same locations, illustrating the ways some artists narrate their location through landscape while simultaneously engaging with visual traditions beyond the island. In her conclusion, she considers artists' recent engagements with ethnic conflict and the idea of the northern city of Jaffna, reminding us that such interventions can portray aesthetically pleasing spaces that are at the same time political territories.

Much is also missing from the narratives in this book. Sri Lanka's contact with the art worlds of Southeast Asia is one glaring omission. Naturally, there are quite a few studies in the fields of history and Buddhism about Sri Lanka's contact with Southeast Asia.⁵⁸ But there are spaces and processes of connectedness that could be explored in the field of art history as well. Paintings at Myinkaba Kubyauk-gyi Temple in Pagan in Myanmar depict scenes from the Pali chronicle *Mahavamsa*, written in Sri Lanka in the 5th century CE.⁵⁹ Paintings illustrating the *Mahavamsa* also appear at a number of temples in Sri Lanka starting in the early 19th century.⁶⁰ What might a comparison between the murals of the *Mahavamsa* in Sri Lanka and Myanmar reveal about connected art histories in the Indian Ocean?

The connections to Southeast Asia were not just through Buddhism; most research on the island's contact with the Islamic world has

been focused on both trading and religious networks.⁶¹ But the tomb of a possibly Hadrami migrant inside the Ketchimalai Mosque in Beruwala (figures 13a and b) in southern Sri Lanka reveals the possibility of connected networks of visual and religious practices across the Indian Ocean. Are the forms, materials, rituals and patronage patterns in this part of Sri Lanka similar to those found at the keramats, or graves that have become sites of worship—generally the graves of Hadrami migrants and their descendants—in Singapore (figure 14), Indonesia and Malaysia?⁶² There is still much to be explored in these inter-Asia networks, agents, practices, processes and spaces.

However, this first attempt to rethink Sri Lanka's art histories showcases some of the most thought-provoking research currently being done, while producing a polyphony of narratives situated on a continuum of local, regional and global visual traditions. The essays in this volume embed Sri Lanka's art histories in various transnational moments, clearly locating the island's artistic heritages within wider webs of interactions. Their innovative approaches and subjects cut across the history and the geography of the island, illuminating previously unseen aspects and areas of its art and—by attending closely to the visual surfaces of various forms and mediums—opening pathways that cut against previous assumptions shaping the landscape of its art histories. As they unpack and complicate a variety of images for us, the writers of these essays credit makers and patrons with intentionality. Were it not for space and time limitations, many more stories could have been shared, as they trace various connections to the island in precise and complex ways. There is still much to explore and many new voices to listen to.⁶³ This intervention is a first step along untrodden paths, and it is hoped that others in the field will join in these conversations about Sri Lanka and its connected art histories.

Acknowledgements

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Notes

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- 1 Senake Bandaranayake, "Introductory Note: Sri Lanka and the 'Silk Road' of the Sea", in *Sri Lanka and the Silk Road of the Sea*, edited by Senake Bandaranayake, Lorna Dewaraja, Roland Silva and K.D.G. Wimalaratne, 2nd edition, Colombo: Sri Lanka Institute of International Relations, Central Cultural Fund, Sri Lanka National Commission for UNESCO, 2003, p. 9.
- 2 G. Baldacchino, "Editorial: Islands: Objects of Representation", *Geografiska Annaler, Series B, Human Geography*, Vol. 87, No. 4, Special Issue: *Islands: Objects of Representation*, 2005, p. 247.
- 3 Simon Casie Chitty, *Ceylon Gazetteer*, Ceylon:

- Cotta Church Mission Press, 1834; reprint Colombo: PLW & Co., 1989, p. 29.
- 4 Baldacchino, "Editorial", p. 248.
 - 5 Numerous early publications on Sri Lankan art history contain the term "Sinhala". As the following list of publications shows, the term "Sinhala" was applied to architecture, sculpture, painting and the decorative arts. Ananda K. Coomaraswamy, *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art: Being a Monograph on Mediaeval Sinhalese Arts and Crafts, mainly as Surviving in the Eighteenth Century, with an Account of the Structure of Society and the Status of the Craftsmen*, 3rd edition, New York: Pantheon Books, 1979; T.U. de Silva, *Decorative Sinhalese Art*, Colombo: Ceylon Daily News, 1940; Sarkis Katchadourian, R.V. Leyden and H.L.M. Williams, *Sinhalese Frescoes: From Sigiriya and Polonnaruwa*, Bombay: Bombay Art Society, 1940; D.T. Devendra, *Classical Sinhalese Sculpture, c. 300 B.C. to A.D. 1000*, London: A. Tiranti, 1958; Senerat Paranavitana, *Sinhalayo*, Colombo: Lake House Investments Ltd., 1967; Senerat Paranavitana, *Art of the Ancient Sinhalese*, Colombo: Lake House Investments Ltd., 1971; Senake Bandaranayake, *Sinhalese Monastic Architecture*, Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1974.
 - 6 Apart from being a colonial emphasis, this stress on "Sinhaleanness" can perhaps also be seen as a response to colonialism; and, although it clearly emphasizes one ethnic group, it was also perhaps a way to distinguish the island from India.
 - 7 The necessity to complicate binaries between the precolonial and colonial, and the notion of recycling precolonial traditions, have been well illustrated recently by Sujit Sivasundaram in *Islanded Britain, Sri Lanka & the Bounds of an Indian Ocean Colony*, Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 2013.
 - 8 John Rogers, "Historical Images in the British Period", in *Sri Lanka: History and the Roots of Conflict*, edited by Jonathan Spencer, London: Routledge, 1990, p. 87.
 - 9 John Rogers, "Colonial Perceptions of Ethnicity and Culture in Nineteenth-Century Sri Lanka", *Society and Ideology*, 1993, pp. 101–02. Rogers has explored the history of social identities in Sri Lanka, arguing that the British gave primacy to what we now term ethnicity over other social categories such as caste, religion, language and territory (pp. 98–99). In exploring the earlier histories of social identities in Sri Lanka, Rogers discovers that caste or occupational status played a more significant role than ethnicity (John Rogers, "Post-Orientalism and the Interpretation of Premodern and Modern Political Identities: The Case of Sri Lanka", *The Journal of Asian Studies*, Vol. 53, No. 1, February 1994, pp. 13–14). Racial identities existed in earlier periods, but they "were by no means the only important political identities" (John D. Rogers, "Racial Identities and Politics in Early Modern Sri Lanka", in *The Concept of Race in South Asia*, edited by Peter Robb, Delhi and New York: Oxford University Press, 1995, p. 148). In a later article, Rogers refines his argument about the relationship between ethnicity and caste in Sri Lanka by noting that "caste" or "cast" was an important category in early British rule, but was replaced by nation or race or ethnicity due to a new sociology brought about by the 1833 Colebrooke-Cameron reforms (John D. Rogers, "Early British Rule and Social Classification in Lanka", *Modern Asian Studies*, Vol. 38, No. 3, 2004, pp. 639–45).
 - 10 For a discussion of the rediscovery of Anuradhapura, see Sivasundaram, *Islanded...*, pp. 149–55. For a discussion on the rediscovery of Polonnaruwa, see Sujatha Arundathi Meegama, "South Indian or Sri Lankan? The Hindu Temples in Polonnaruwa, Sri Lanka", *Artibus Asiae*, Vol. 70, No. 1, 2010, pp. 25–45.
 - 11 John Rogers, "Historical Images", p. 89.
 - 12 Ismeth Raheem and Percy Colin Thome, *Images of British Ceylon: Nineteenth Century Photography of Sri Lanka*, Singapore: Times Editions, 2000, pp. 44–54.
 - 13 Major Jonathan Forbes, *Eleven Years in Ceylon: Comprising Sketches of the Field Sports and Natural History of that Colony, and an Account of its History and Antiquities*, 2nd edition, London: R. Bentley, 1841; Samuel Baker, *Eight Years' Wanderings in Ceylon*, London: Longman, Brown, Green, and Longmans, 1855; Henry W. Cave, *The Ruined Cities of Ceylon*, 3rd edition, London: Hutchinson & Co., 1904.
 - 14 For an excellent critique of Coomaraswamy's engagement with Sri Lankan art, see Senake Bandaranayake, "Patrons, Producer, Product: Ananda Coomaraswamy and Approaches to the Study of Traditional Sri Lankan Art", in *Continuities and Transformation: Studies in Sri Lankan Archaeology and History*, Colombo: Social Scientists' Association, 2012, pp. 265–97. It was published earlier in 1980; in fact, Tapati Guha-Thakurta notes that "the art historian in him also emerged during these years—the years he spent in Sri Lanka studying the arts and crafts of the island" (Tapati Guha-Thakurta, "Coomaraswamy, Ananda Kentish", Grove Art Online, Oxford Art Online, <http://www.oxfordartonline.com>).

- ezlibproxy1.ntu.edu.sg/subscriber/article/grove/art/T019287, accessed December 16, 2015).
- 15 Sonal Khullar, "Coomaraswamy, Ananda Kentish", *Encyclopedia of Aesthetics*, Vol. 2, edited by Michael Kelly, New York: Oxford University Press, 2014, pp. 172–75.
 - 16 See James S. Crouch, *A Bibliography of Ananda Kentish Coomaraswamy*, New Delhi: Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts and Manohar, 2002.
 - 17 In his 1905 letter to the Kandyan chiefs, he mentions that he was in the field for two years. Ananda Coomaraswamy, "An Open Letter to the Kandyan Chiefs: An Expert on Kandyan Architecture and Painting in the Days of Old", reproduced in *The Sri Lanka Reader*, edited by John Clifford Holt, Durham and London: Duke University Press, 2011, p. 321. For more details on Ethel Coomaraswamy in Sri Lanka, see Kumari Jayawardena, *The White Woman's Other Burden: Western Women and South Asia During British Rule*, New York and London: Routledge, 1995, pp. 167–71; and Ismeth Raheem, "Ananda and Ethel Coomaraswamy and the Making of *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art* (1908)", July 25, 2013, Monthly Lectures, National Trust.
 - 18 In this first book, Coomaraswamy was perhaps responding to the colonialist rationale that juxtaposed the glorious ancient cities of colonized societies with their present state of ruins that then justified the colonial presence in the colonies (Bandaranayake, "Patrons, Producer, Product", pp. 270–71).
 - 19 Coomaraswamy, *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art*, p. V. Bandaranayake points out that by challenging one colonialist belief, Coomaraswamy was influenced by another: the diffusionist theory that "explain[s] the achievements of one culture by transposing its origins, sources and creative dynamic...to cultures outside itself" (Bandaranayake, "Patrons, Producer, Product", p. 271).
 - 20 Coomaraswamy, *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art*, p. 18.
 - 21 T.K. Sabapathy when examining Coomaraswamy's *History of Indian and Indonesian Art* (1927), the first publication to include Southeast Asian art, points to a number of problematic statements about the so-called Indianization of Southeast Asian art. T.K. Sabapathy, "Developing Regionalist Perspectives in South-East Asian Art Historiography", in *The Second Asia Pacific Triennial of Contemporary Art*, Brisbane: Queensland Art Gallery, 1996, pp. 2–3.
 - 22 Coomaraswamy, *Mediaeval Sinhalese Art*, pp. 170, 177.
 - 23 Sabapathy states, when examining Coomaraswamy's discussion of a Cambodian Harihara, that "the image vanishes into the fabric of Indian art history, erased, rendered invisible and inconsequential" (Sabapathy, "Developing Regionalist Perspectives", p. 3).
 - 24 Sabapathy, "Developing Regionalist Perspectives", p. 2.
 - 25 Mark Ravinder Frost, "That Great Ocean of Idealism: Calcutta, the Tagore Circle, and the Idea of Asia, 1900–1920", in *Indian Ocean Studies: Cultural, Social and Political Perspectives*, edited by Shanti Moorthy and Ashraf Jamal, New York and London: Routledge/Taylor & Francis Group, 2010, p. 267.
 - 26 Coomaraswamy, "An Open Letter to the Kandyan Chiefs", p. 325.
 - 27 "Coomaraswamy's address on being elected president of the Society: The Ceylon Social Reform Society", *Sadaresa*, Colombo, English Supplement, I.11, August 4, 1905; see Crouch, *Bibliography of Ananda Kentish Coomaraswamy*, p. 153, C62.
 - 28 H.L. Seneviratne, by focusing on music and theatre, highlights a larger concerted effort by intellectuals and practitioners to forge a national tradition in the British colonial period. He points to two phases in this search for a national art: a first phase, which distinguishes the indigenous from the Western, and a second phase that was conceived along ethnic lines. H.L. Seneviratne, "Towards a National Art", in *Home and the World: Essays in Honor of Sarath Amungama*, Colombo: Siripa Publishers, 2010, pp. 73–101.
 - 29 Paranavitana was hired as an epigraphist by the then archaeological commissioner, A.M. Hocart, in 1922 (*Senerat Paranavitana Commemoration Volume*, edited by Leelananda Prematilleke, Karthigesu Indrapala and J.E. van Lohuizen-De-Leeuw, Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1978, p. ix). His first historical article, "The Cholas and Ceylon", appeared in 1924 (Prematilleke et al., p. 2). Like Coomaraswamy, Paranavitana had a command of a number of languages, and freely quoted from various literary sources to argue his points about any topic (Sirima Kiribamune, "Some Reflections on Professor Paranavitana's Contribution to History", *The Ceylon Journal of the Humanities*, Vol. 1, No. 1, January 1970, p. 77).
 - 30 Kiribamune, "Some Reflections", p. 77.
 - 31 Apart from the two reviewed in this essay, a few others also focus on the broad history of the island's artistic heritage: "Art of Ancient Ceylon", *New Review* (Calcutta), Vol. 13, No. 75, March 1941, pp. 185–95; *Ceylon, Paintings from Temple, Shrine and Rock*, UNESCO World Art

- Series, No. 8 (Paris), New York Graphic Society, by arrangement with UNESCO, 1957, pp. 17–28; *Glimpses of Ceylon's Past*, Colombo: Lake House Investments Ltd., 1972; and *Sinhalayo*, Colombo: Lake House Investments Ltd., 1967, 2nd revised edition, 1970.
- 32 Senerat Paranavitana, "Sinhalese Art and Culture", *Journal of the Royal Society of Arts*, Vol. 98, No. 4822, 1950, pp. 588–605. Reprinted as "Sinhalese Art and Culture", *Souvenir Catalogue of International Exhibition of Paintings, Colombo Plan Exhibition*, 1952, pp. 9–21.
- 33 Paranavitana, "Sinhalese Art and Culture", p. 593.
- 34 Paranavitana, "Sinhalese Art and Culture", p. 601. For more such images, see the essay by R. Mahalakshmi in this volume.
- 35 Paranavitana, "Sinhalese Art and Culture", p. 588.
- 36 However, these writings were produced before the rise of linguistic nationalism in 1956.
- 37 Senerat Paranavitana, *Art of the Ancient Sinhalese*, Colombo: Lake House Investments Ltd., 1971.
- 38 Paranavitana, *Art of the Ancient Sinhalese*, p. 1.
- 39 "The arts and crafts which flourished in ancient India in the third century BC were thus transplanted into Ceylon and, in the course of the succeeding centuries, developed there in accordance with the distinctive character of the Sinhalese people." Senerat Paranavitana, "Architecture (Ceylon)", *Encyclopedia of Buddhism*, edited by G.P. Malalasekera, *Volume of Specimen Articles* (Colombo), 1957, pp. 8–22, cited in Senake Bandaranayake, "Approaches to the External Factor in Sri Lanka's Historical Formation", in *Continuities and Transformation* (see note 14), pp. 105–06.
- 40 He further notes that "The northern tip of the Island and the eastern seaboard form, as it were, an extension of South India as regards the race, the language and the religion of their present inhabitants." Paranavitana, *Art of the Ancient Sinhalese*, p. 5. Of course, he is quick to point out that "the ancient art of Ceylon...possesses a distinctive character of its own, while at the same time exhibiting enough traits to show its origin and affinities" (pp. 6–7).
- 41 Paranavitana, *Art of the Ancient Sinhalese*, pp. 1–9, 11–15, 17, 19–24 and 27.
- 42 Similar formulations have been made by foreign scholars as well. Bandaranayake cites a British cultural historian, Quaritch Wales, who states that "the art of Ceylon is in general a reflection of India, without original developments" (Bandaranayake, "Approaches to the External Factor", p. 105).
- 43 Senake Bandaranayake, *Sri Lankan Painting in the 20th Century*, Colombo: National Trust, 2009.
- 44 Senake Bandaranayake, "Sri Lanka and Monsoon Asia: Hypotheses on the Unity and Differentiation of Cultures", in *Continuities and Transformation*, p. 27.
- 45 Senake Bandaranayake, "Preface", in *Continuities and Transformation*, p. 8.
- 46 Senake Bandaranayake, "Introduction", in *Continuities and Transformation*, p. 15.
- 47 "Sri Lanka and Monsoon Asia" was first published in 1978, then in 1980; "Approaches to the External Factor" was first published in 1978. Both were published again in *Continuities and Transformation*, pp. 23–56 and 91–119.
- 48 Bandaranayake, "Sri Lanka and Monsoon Asia", pp. 28–29.
- 49 Bandaranayake, "Sri Lanka and Monsoon Asia", pp. 47 and 52.
- 50 Bandaranayake, "Approaches to the External Factor", pp. 98–100. Bandaranayake does not use the term "art history", but he seems to conflate history with art history.
- 51 Bandaranayake, "Approaches to the External Factor", p. 107. Bandaranayake's approach reflects the recent emphasis on Indian Ocean studies: see *Indian Ocean Studies: Cultural, Social and Political Perspectives*, edited by Moorthy and Jamal, 2010.
- 52 Bandaranayake, "Approaches to the External Factor", p. 91.
- 53 This deeply linked binary of the local and the global has begun to dominate not only our framing of contemporary art, but also the way we understand how people, ideas and objects operated in the early modern and ancient art worlds. Here it is useful to recall Monica Juneja's understanding of global art history: although the term "global" implies a contemporary phenomenon, Juneja does not see global art as a modern or postmodern phenomenon; instead, she sees the necessity to examine "historical forms of mobility". Noting the different definitions of "global art history", Juneja also takes pains to differentiate her notion of global art history from world art, which examines art from different cultures. She argues that "The attempt to break away from a Eurocentric delineation of the subject leads to an inclusion of the 'world' in an additive sort of way"; but as inclusion alone does not engage with the problematic frameworks in the foundations of art history, she highlights the necessity of explaining the "processes of connectedness" that lead to the creation of global art histories. "Interview with Monica Juneja", *Culture of Excellence: Asia*

- and *Europe in a Global Context*, <http://www.asia-europe.uni-heidelberg.de/de/aktuelles/nachrichten/detail/m/interview-with-prof-monica-juneja.html>, accessed on May 21, 2015.
- 54 “Interview with Monica Juneja”.
- 55 Rebecca Brown, in her critique of “multiple, alternative, equivalent modernities around the globe”, argues that inclusion or expansion of the canon is not enough; she seeks to dismantle the very foundation of modernism by foregrounding the “periphery as central to the modern”. Rebecca Brown, “Response: Provincializing Modernity: From Derivative to Traditional”, response to Partha Mitter in *Art Bulletin*, Vol. 90, No. 4, December 2008, p. 555.
- 56 See *Marg*, Vol. 1, No. 3, April 1947 and Martin Russell, *George Key: Introduction and Biographical Note*, Bombay: Marg, 1950. As early as 1952, Marg also published a volume dedicated to Sri Lanka’s art histories. See *Marg*, Vol. 5, No. 3, Special Issue: *Ceylon*, April 1952.
- 57 Sharmini Pereira, “Contemporary Sri Lanka: Conflicts of Interest”, in *Indian Highway*, London: Serpentine Gallery and Koenig Books, 2008, p. 206.
- 58 For a recent intervention, see Anne M. Blackburn, “Buddhist Connections in the Indian Ocean: Changes in Monastic Mobility, 1000–1500”, *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient*, Vol. 58, No. 3, 2015, pp. 237–66.
- 59 Hema Goonatilake, “The 12th Century Paintings of the *Mahavamsa* in Burma”, *Sri Lanka Puravidya Sambita*, Vol. 2, 2006, pp. 71–80.
- 60 Sujatha Arundathi Meegama, “Representing and Invoking a Theravada Buddhist Past: History Paintings at the Dambulla Cave Temple in Sri Lanka”, unpublished paper.
- 61 See essays by Sirima Kiribamune and Lorna Dewaraja in *Sri Lanka and the Silk Road of the Sea*. Recently, Ronit Ricci has shifted our attention to literary networks in South and Southeast Asia, arguing for works of literature as “dynamic sites of interaction” between local Islamic communities and the wider worlds of Islam; on this, see particularly her study of a Malay manuscript from Sri Lanka written in Arabic: Ronit Ricci, “Remembering Java’s Islamization: A View from Sri Lanka”, ARI Working Paper, No. 153, June 2011, www.nus.ari.edu.sg/pub/wps.htm. Within this framework, a study of the kerises (double-edged daggers) in Sri Lanka owned by Malay families could also produce rich narratives about Islamic and Southeast Asian encounters in Sri Lanka.
- 62 Sumit Mandal, “Popular Sites of Prayer, Transoceanic Migration, and Cultural Diversity: Exploring the Significance of *Keramat* in Southeast Asia”, *Modern Asian Studies*, Vol. 46, No. 2, 2012, pp. 355–72.
- 63 It is exciting to see a group of scholars who generally work on India now turning their attention to Sri Lanka. Presentations at the first AISLS Art History Workshop included Pia Brancaccio, “Monumentality in Buddhist Sculpture”; Divya Kumar-Dumas, “Reception to Sigiriya Painting: Present and Past”; and Janice Leoshko, “Bodh Gaya and Sri Lanka” (*Developing Perspectives on the Art Histories of Sri Lanka*, AISLS Art History Workshop, Colombo, July 27, 2015).

Facing page

Tissa Dagoba, Tissamaharama.
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Tibor Bognár/collection-age
fotostock.

